

Survey Design and Analysis Framework

Birthday Invitation Survey - Capstone Documentation

N = 70 respondents

1. Theoretical framework

The persistence of individual gift-giving at children's birthday parties, despite widespread private dissatisfaction, is best understood through Cristina Bicchieri's account of social norms. Bicchieri (2006, p. 11) argues that a social norm is sustained not by individual preference but by two interlocking sets of beliefs: empirical expectations - what most people believe others actually do - and normative expectations - what most people believe others think one ought to do, and whether they would sanction deviation. Both conditions must hold simultaneously for a norm to exert behavioural force. A parent who privately finds the gift pile excessive will nonetheless bring a wrapped present if they believe most other parents will bring one (empirical expectation) and that arriving without one would be noticed and judged (normative expectation). Neither belief needs to be accurate; it is sufficient that they are held.

Bicchieri (2006, pp. 41-42) argues that each parent's behaviour reinforces the very expectations that make deviation feel risky, regardless of what anyone privately thinks: the norm is self-sustaining not because participants endorse it, but because no individual can safely deviate without evidence that others would do the same. Bicchieri (2017, p. 119) identifies this as a problem of uncertainty about others' behaviour: norm change depends on reducing that uncertainty, on making it credible and visible that others are ready to move together.

This dynamic is closely related to the concept of pluralistic ignorance (Allport, 1924; Miller & McFarland, 1987), which Bicchieri (2017, p.109) draws on in her account of norm maintenance: members of a group privately reject a norm while publicly conforming to it, each incorrectly assuming that others genuinely endorse it. In the birthday gift context, pluralistic ignorance would predict a specific and testable asymmetry: parents comfortable with the idea of receiving a collective gift invitation - since it requires no public act of deviation from their side - but unwilling to send one, since sending requires being the first visible mover against a norm they assume others privately support. The asymmetry between receiving and sending is therefore not simply a matter of personal courage; it is a structural feature of the norm's maintenance mechanism, produced by the gap between private attitudes and public behaviour that pluralistic ignorance generates.

Bicchieri's framework also provides a basis for predicting which design features might reduce the perceived social risk of sending such an invitation. Her distinction between risk sensitivity - a relatively stable individual trait - and risk perception - which varies across contexts depending on perceived stakes and the clarity of social expectations (Bicchieri, 2017, pp. 172-175) - suggests that design choices which reduce ambiguity about what is expected, or which make the deviation appear more socially endorsed, should lower risk perception even among naturally cautious senders. This theoretical prediction motivates both the framing comparison (different personas offering different implicit signals about social endorsement) and the contribution format comparison (age-scaled format as a clarity and coordination device) tested in the present survey.

However, these predictions should be treated as theoretically motivated hypotheses rather than foregone conclusions. For H2, it is possible that the open-ended format outperforms the age-scaled one: the absence of a specific figure may reduce perceived pressure, making the invitation easier to adopt. Alternatively, the age-scaled rule may be interpreted as arbitrary or bossy if the scaling principle is not seen as meaningful in context, in which case it may fail to reduce perceived risk. For H3, it is possible that no framing proves sufficient: if the barrier is primarily structural rather than communicative, personas may shift relative preference without meaningfully raising absolute willingness to send. The survey is designed to test these possibilities empirically rather than confirm a predetermined outcome.

2. Research Question

Which combination of framing style and contribution format makes parents most willing to send a birthday invitation that proposes a shared group gift?

This question emerged from a broader observation: individual gift-giving at children's birthday parties is widely perceived as burdensome, yet the norm persists. The survey investigates whether specific design choices in a digital invitation can reduce the social risk of deviating from this norm, and which combination of framing and contribution structure is most effective in doing so.

3. Study Design

3a. Design structure

The survey employed a mixed-method design combining a quantitative within-subjects experiment - testing the effects of framing style and contribution format on four rated measures - with correlational analysis of the relationships between those measures, and descriptive analysis of global attitude items and open-text responses. Each participant rated six invitations, producing a 3 (framing style) × 2 (contribution format) fully crossed within-subjects design.

The sample was recruited through a combination of convenience and snowball sampling via the researcher's personal and professional networks. While this approach is appropriate for an exploratory study of this scale and the research question carries no sensitive dimensions, it may slightly overrepresent respondents with a reflective or cosmopolitan orientation toward social norms, and findings should be interpreted accordingly.

The six invitations

Invitation	Framing style	Contribution format
Inv1	Elephant in the Room	Open-ended
Inv2	Comic Strip	Age-scaled
Inv3	Scientist	Open-ended
Inv4	Elephant in the Room	Age-scaled

Inv5	Scientist	Age-scaled
Inv6	Comic Strip	Open-ended

Variables and conditions

Variable	Type	Levels
Framing style	Independent variable	Elephant in the Room / Scientist / Comic Strip
Contribution format	Independent variable	Age-scaled (£1/year) / Open-ended (any amount)
Clarity	Dependent variable	1–7 scale
Appropriateness	Dependent variable (face-threat: sender)	1–7 scale
Pressure	Dependent variable (face-threat: receiver)	1–7 scale
Willingness to send	Primary outcome variable	1–7 scale
Comfort receiving	Baseline attitude measure	3-category global item
Demographics	Background variables	Gender, spend, party frequency, prior experience

The within-subjects design was chosen to reduce error variance by controlling for individual differences in social anxiety and norm sensitivity (Field, 2018, p. 60). This is particularly important at a sample size of 70, where a between-subjects design would have produced groups of approximately 11 participants per invitation - insufficient for reliable detection of framing effects. By having each participant rate all six invitations, the design effectively compensates for a modest sample size without sacrificing statistical power.

3b. Measures and their theoretical roles

Four measures were collected per invitation, each serving a distinct theoretical purpose.

Measure	Theoretical role	Design implication
Clarity	Communication design: can the message be processed quickly and without excessive cognitive effort?	Points toward layout, length, and visual hierarchy decisions in invitation templates
Appropriateness	Face-threat, direct route (Brown & Levinson): does sending this reflect badly on me as a host, regardless of how guests feel?	Points toward framing decisions: which persona or communication style makes the ask feel most socially appropriate for the host to make?
Pressure	Face-threat, indirect route (Brown & Levinson): does this impose on my guests, which then reflects badly on me for imposing?	Points toward wording and tone decisions: how the contribution is described, how optional it feels, what register is used

Willingness to send	Primary outcome: the aggregate of all three above	Overall measure of invitation effectiveness
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Brown and Levinson (1987, pp. 61–62, 74–76) define face as the public self-image individuals seek to maintain, distinguishing between positive face - the desire to be liked and approved of - and negative face - the desire for autonomy and freedom from imposition. It is important to note that appropriateness and pressure are not two separate threats to two separate people - they are two routes by which the sender's face is threatened. Both measures ultimately bear on the sender's decision, since it is the sender who must weigh the social risk before acting - but they arrive there via different mechanisms. Appropriateness concerns the sender's own positive face: does sending this invitation risk making me appear grabby or socially incompetent? Pressure concerns the imposition on the receiver's negative face: does this obligation on my guests reflect badly on me as a host? In both cases it is the sender's calculation, made before acting, that the survey measures are designed to capture.

Comfort receiving was measured as a single global item rather than a per-invitation dependent variable. It serves as a baseline against which willingness-to-send scores can be compared, establishing the scale of the sender–receiver asymmetry independently of any design choice.

3c. Ethics

Ethical approval was obtained through the LIS institutional ethics review process prior to data collection. Informed consent was collected at the start of the survey: participants were informed of the study's purpose, the voluntary nature of participation, their right to withdraw at any point, and how their data would be stored and used. No personally identifiable information was collected beyond basic demographic items (gender, primary school experience). The ethics application form and full consent text are included in the appendix.

4. Hypotheses

H1 - Primary hypothesis

Willingness to send a collective gift invitation would be significantly lower than comfort receiving one. This prediction was grounded in Bicchieri's (2006) account of pluralistic ignorance: parents continue to bring individual gifts because they believe others expect it, not because they privately endorse the norm. The expected asymmetry - most parents comfortable receiving, few willing to send - would constitute direct empirical evidence of this dynamic.

H1 was confirmed, and more strongly than anticipated. 68.6% of participants reported being comfortable receiving a collective gift invitation, while only 20% reported high willingness to send even the best-performing invitation (Inv 4, Elephant in the Room, Suggested Amount). Even at its peak, mean willingness reached only 3.46 out of 7. This asymmetry - most parents receptive to receiving, very few willing to send - constitutes direct empirical evidence of pluralistic ignorance: parents appear reluctant to initiate a practice they would privately welcome, likely because they underestimate how acceptable others would find it.

H2 - Secondary hypothesis

Age-scaled contribution format (£1 per year of the child's age) was tentatively predicted to produce higher willingness to send than open-ended format (any amount). The theoretical basis, drawn from Bicchieri (2017, pp. 172–175), is that specifying a contribution amount reduces perceived social ambiguity: contributors know what is expected, which lowers perceived risk for both sender and receiver.

H2 was not supported. No significant difference in willingness to send was found between the open amount format and the suggested amount format when averaged across framings ($\chi^2(1) = 0.170$, $p = .680$). While interaction patterns between format and framing were observable in the data, these should be interpreted with caution: a methodological limitation of the study was that several participants did not appear to register the difference between the two contribution formats, raising the possibility that any format-level effects reflect noise rather than genuine responses to the manipulation. The relationship between contribution structure and willingness to send remains an open question for future research with a more salient format manipulation.

H3 - Tertiary hypothesis

The three persona-based framings (Elephant in the Room, Scientist, Comic Strip) were predicted to lower the social barrier to sending a collective gift invitation by offering parents a narrative "shield" - a character or voice to speak through, reducing the face-threat of making a direct financial request. Drawing on Brown and Levinson's (1987) politeness theory, the personas were expected to increase willingness to send relative to a faceless request.

H3 was not confirmed. The framing effect was statistically significant ($\chi^2(2) = 14.0$, $p < .001$), indicating that the three personas were not perceived as equivalent. Only the Elephant in the Room framing distinguished itself, achieving significantly higher willingness than both Comic Strip and Scientist ($p < .001$ and $p = .021$ respectively); Comic Strip and Scientist did not differ from one another ($p = .121$). However, absolute willingness remained low across all three framings, with means ranging from 2.61 to 3.21 on a 7-point scale. Personas influence relative preference but are insufficient on their own to overcome the underlying social reluctance to send. Whether other framing approaches might prove more effective remains an open question for future research.

5. Participants

Characteristic	N	%
Female	55	79%
Male	10	14%
Blank/no gender response	5	7%
Typical spend: £10–£19	52	78%
Typical spend: under £10	6	9%
Attend 5–10 parties/year	47	70%
Prior group gift experience: yes	32	48%

Prior group gift experience: would consider	30	45%
Prior group gift experience: would not consider	5	7%

The sample is predominantly female (79%), consistent with the broader pattern in which social coordination around children's activities disproportionately falls to mothers. This demographic concentration limits the generalisability of findings across all parents and should be acknowledged as a scope condition rather than a representative sample.

The concentration of respondents in the £10–£19 spending bracket (78%) is consistent with self-reported norms among UK parents more broadly - a finding corroborated by community discussion on Mumsnet, where £10–£20 emerges as the most commonly cited amount for a class birthday party gift (Mumsnet, 2025).

6. Limitations

6a. Fixed invitation order

Invitation order was fixed across all participants due to platform constraints: Microsoft Forms does not support randomisation of question blocks, and the university required the use of Microsoft Forms. Counterbalancing or random assignment of invitation order would be the standard methodological approach to control for order effects such as fatigue (respondents tiring by invitations 5 and 6) and contrast effects (earlier invitations colouring judgements of later ones). The absence of randomisation means order effects cannot be ruled out as a partial explanation for any differences between invitations. However, the volume and specificity of open-text responses across all six invitations - including the final two - suggests that fatigue effects, if present, did not substantially reduce engagement. Respondents continued to offer detailed critique, personal anecdote, and design suggestions on later invitations, which is inconsistent with the pattern of disengagement that severe order effects would produce.

6b. Image resolution

Invitation images were embedded at limited resolution within the Microsoft Forms interface. To mitigate this, each invitation included a redirect link to a higher-resolution version. Qualitative responses suggest respondents engaged with sufficient detail to critique specific wording and visual elements, indicating that image quality did not prevent engagement. However, some variability in how closely respondents examined each invitation cannot be excluded.

6c. Format manipulation perception - primary limitation

The most significant methodological limitation concerns the extent to which respondents reliably perceived the difference between age-scaled and open-ended contribution versions. Each framing style appeared twice - once with an open-ended link and once with a suggested £1-per-year-of-age amount - and respondents were invited to rate all six invitations in sequence. Despite introductory explanations and orange highlighting of the contribution format differences, qualitative responses suggest that a meaningful subset of participants did not register the distinction between paired versions.

Several respondents explicitly described age-scaled invitations as identical to their open-ended counterpart:

"Isn't this the same as (1)?" - Respondent 10, on Invitation 4 (Elephant in the Room, age-scaled)

"Is this the same as the first invitation? [...] Looks the same as the second invitation." - Respondent 66, on Invitations 4 and 5

Among those who did notice the age-scaled format, responses were often focused on surface features - specific wording such as 'guiding star language' - rather than the underlying contribution structure. Only a small number engaged directly with the format distinction itself.

This pattern has a direct implication for interpreting the quantitative format comparisons. The weak and inconsistent effect of contribution format across framings may reflect inconsistent perception of the manipulation as much as genuine format preference. Where respondents did not notice the difference, their ratings would be driven entirely by framing rather than format, diluting any true format effect. The format comparison should therefore be treated as exploratory rather than conclusive.

A more controlled test would either present the two formats side by side with the difference explicitly labelled, or employ a between-subjects design with a dedicated manipulation check question confirming that respondents had registered the contribution structure before rating it. A two-stage design - first testing full invitation combinations for ecological validity, then isolating the payment format using minimal matched vignettes - would allow these two research questions to be addressed separately and more cleanly.

6d. Likert scale as ordinal data

The 1-7 rating scales used for all per-invitation measures are technically ordinal: they establish order (higher = more willing / clear / appropriate) but do not guarantee that the psychological distance between each adjacent point is equal. Calculating means from ordinal data is a common and generally accepted practice in survey-based social research, but it rests on an assumption that cannot be formally verified. Non-parametric tests (Friedman and Durbin-Conover post-hoc) were used as the primary inferential analyses precisely because they do not require this assumption, with means reported alongside them following standard practice in the field.

6e. Engagement as positive indicator

Despite these limitations, the volume and specificity of open-text responses across all six invitations is a notable positive finding. Respondents engaged with sufficient care to offer detailed critique, personal anecdote, and design suggestions, suggesting that birthday gift-giving norms have genuine personal resonance for this sample. This qualitative richness lends ecological validity to the quantitative findings and provides a substantive evidential base for design recommendations that quantitative measures alone could not supply.

7. Analysis Plan

The following analyses were conducted in Jamovi. Results are reported in section 8.

Analysis	Purpose	Jamovi location
Descriptive statistics (mean, median) per invitation × measure	Establish baseline patterns across six conditions	Exploration → Descriptives
Friedman test across 6 willingness scores	Test whether willingness differs significantly across invitations (non-parametric repeated measures)	ANOVA → Repeated Measures (non-parametric)
Durbin-Conover post-hoc : Inv4 vs each other invitation	Identify which specific invitations differ significantly from best performer	ANOVA → Repeated Measures (non-parametric) → Post-hoc
Durbin-Conover post-hoc: framing pairwise (averaged across formats)	Test whether Elephant outperforms Scientist and Comic Strip independently of format	ANOVA → Repeated Measures (non-parametric) → Post-hoc
Spearman correlation: appropriateness + pressure → willingness	Test which face-threat route is the stronger predictor of willingness to send	Regression → Correlation Matrix (Spearman)
Frequency distribution: comfort receiving	Establish baseline attitude for asymmetry calculation	Exploration → Descriptives → Frequencies
Kruskal-Wallis test: willingness scores across primary school experience groups (currently in primary school / previously / both currently and previously / not yet or not applicable)	Test whether life stage - specifically current proximity to the birthday party norm - significantly affects willingness to send across invitation conditions; converts a potential limitation into an empirical finding	ANOVA → One-Way ANOVA → Non-parametric (Kruskal-Wallis)

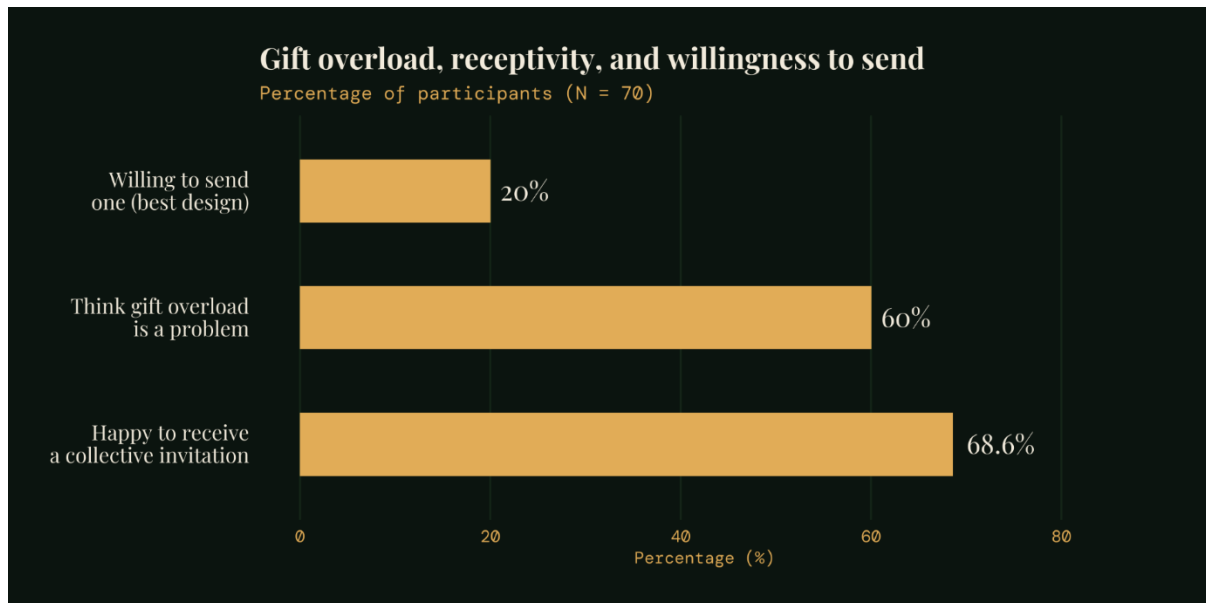
8. Results

All analyses are exploratory. No correction for multiple comparisons was applied. Non-parametric tests were used throughout given the ordinal nature of Likert-type scale data. Post-hoc pairwise comparisons following Friedman tests used the Durbin-Conover method as implemented in Jamovi. Spearman rank-order correlations were used to assess associations between variables.

8a. Willingness to Send: Friedman Test

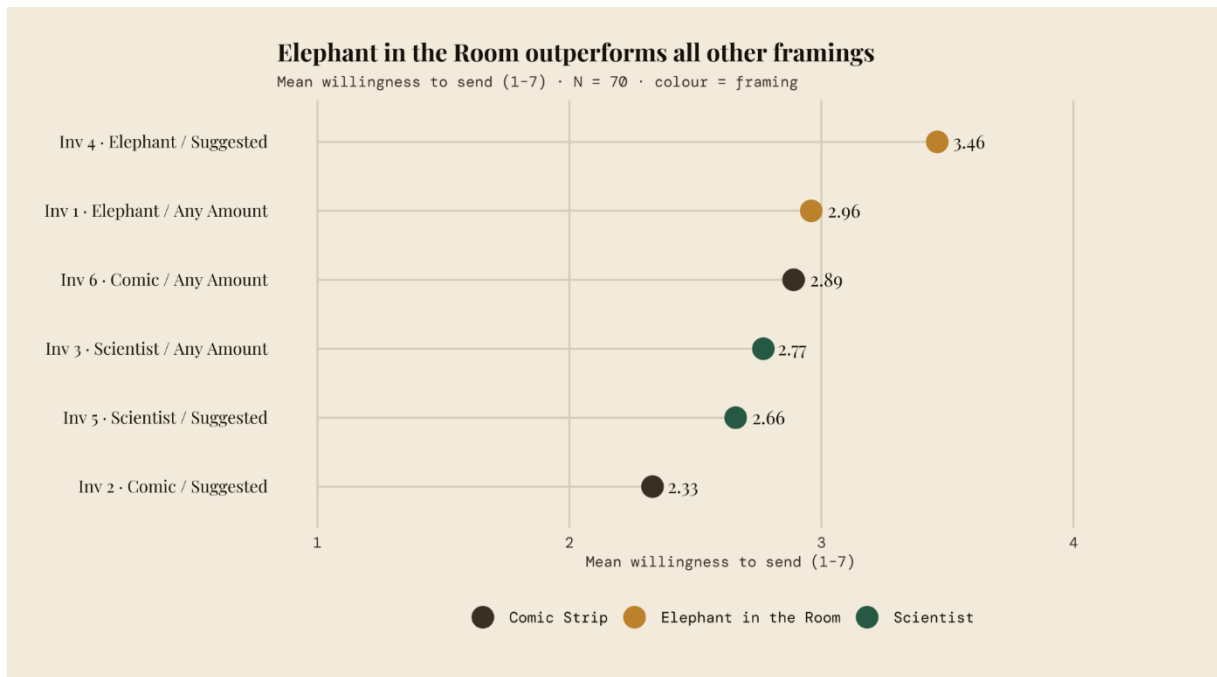
Descriptive statistics for willingness to send (1–7 scale) showed that Inv 4 (Elephant in the Room, Suggested Amount) produced the highest ratings ($M = 3.46$, $Mdn = 4.00$) while Inv 2 (Comic Strip, Suggested Amount) produced the lowest ($M = 2.33$, $Mdn = 2.00$). A Friedman test revealed a statistically significant difference in willingness to send across the six

invitations, $\chi^2(5) = 36.8$, $p < .001$ (Kendall's $W = 0.089$), indicating a small but reliable effect. Post-hoc pairwise comparisons using the Durbin-Conover method showed that Inv 4 was rated significantly higher in willingness than all other invitations (all $p \leq .015$). Inv 2 was rated significantly lower than all other invitations (all $p \leq .009$). The remaining four invitations (Inv 1, 3, 5, and 6) did not differ significantly from one another.



8b. Framing Effect

To isolate the effect of framing independently of contribution format, willingness scores were averaged across the two format conditions within each framing. A Friedman test on these averaged scores was significant, $\chi^2(2) = 14.0$, $p < .001$. Durbin-Conover pairwise comparisons showed that the Elephant in the Room framing ($M = 3.21$) was rated significantly higher in willingness than both the Comic Strip ($M = 2.61$, $p < .001$) and the Scientist ($M = 2.71$, $p = .021$) framings. Comic Strip and Scientist did not differ significantly from one another ($p = .121$).

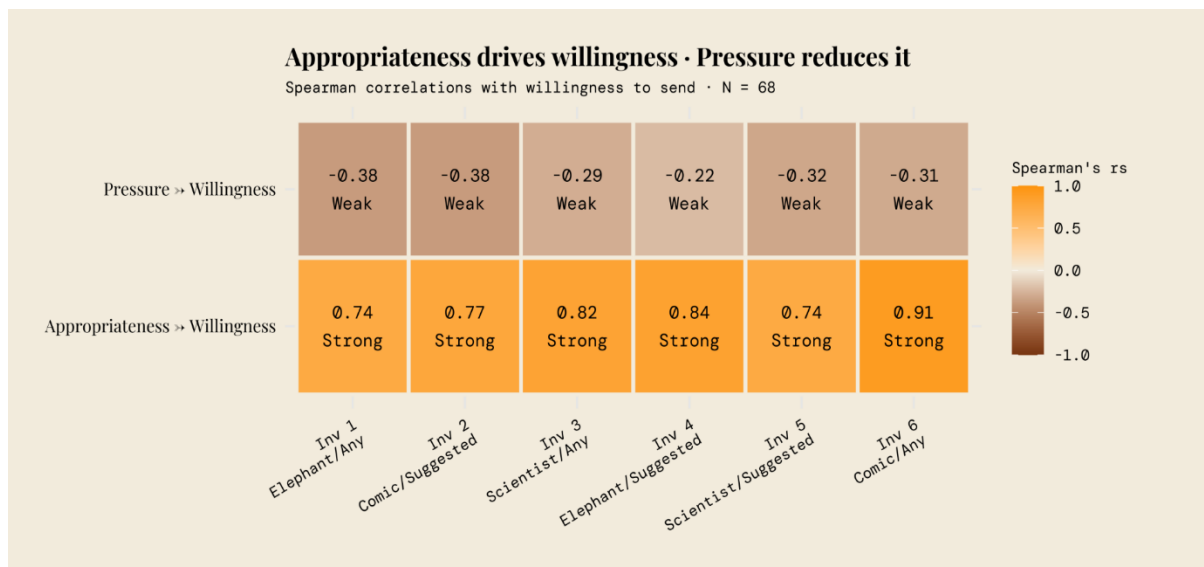


8c. Contribution Format Effect

A Friedman test comparing willingness scores averaged across framings within each format condition found no significant difference between the Any Amount format and the Suggested Amount format, $\chi^2(1) = 0.170$, $p = .680$. Contribution format alone did not significantly predict willingness to send.

8d. Spearman Correlations: Appropriateness and Pressure

Spearman rank-order correlations were computed between perceived appropriateness and willingness to send, and between perceived pressure and willingness to send, for each of the six invitations ($n = 68$ for all correlations). Perceived appropriateness showed a strong positive association with willingness to send across all six invitations (r_s ranging from $+0.735$ to $+0.910$, all $p < .001$). Perceived pressure showed a consistent moderate negative association with willingness across five of the six invitations (r_s ranging from -0.220 to -0.383 , all $p \leq .015$), with the exception of Inv 4 where the relationship did not reach significance ($r_s = -0.220$, $p = .067$).



8e. Frequency Distributions

The majority of participants (68.6%) indicated they would be happy to receive a collective gift invitation, while 14.3% expressed a preference for a standard invitation and 17.1% were neutral. 85.7% of participants indicated they would definitely (52.9%) or probably (32.9%) contribute via a group gift link - substantially higher than the willingness-to-send scores observed for individual invitation designs, suggesting a gap between general receptivity to the concept and endorsement of specific invitation formats, consistent with a pluralistic ignorance interpretation.

8f. Kruskal-Wallis: Willingness by Primary School Experience

A Kruskal-Wallis test examined whether mean willingness to send (averaged across all six invitations) differed by self-reported primary school experience group (currently in primary school, $n = 31$; previously, $n = 27$; both currently and previously, $n = 9$; not yet of primary school age, $n = 3$). No significant difference was found, $H(3) = 1.19$, $p = .756$. Post-hoc pairwise comparisons using the Dunn test confirmed no significant differences between any pair of experience groups (all $p > .74$). Prior or current experience with children in primary school did not significantly predict overall willingness to send a collective gift invitation.

9. Key Qualitative Themes

The quantitative findings establish that a significant gap exists between comfort receiving a collective gift invitation (68.6%) and willingness to send one (20% for the best-performing design). The Spearman correlations suggest that this gap is partly explained by perceived appropriateness and pressure - but numbers alone cannot account for the texture of that reluctance. The open-text responses collected alongside the ratings provide a window into the meaning-making layer: the emotional reasoning, social anxieties, and cultural assumptions that sit beneath the survey scores. Eight themes recurred with sufficient frequency to be treated as structured findings rather than isolated opinions. Taken together, they help explain not just whether parents were willing to send, but why - and point toward the design implications that follow.

Theme	Representative quote	Potential design implication
Too cluttered / too many words	"These options focus on the gift more than the party! The celebration is more important." (R67)	Invitation should carry party facts only; gift information belongs in a separate channel
Patronising / preachy register	"Thank god never a patronising manifesto in 10 points. Group gift, no problem but you don't have to morally justify it." (R25)	Remove justificatory framing; the concept should feel normal, not advocacy
Separate the gift from the invitation	"Send a separate message to explain the group gift." (R37)	Two-phase model: invitation carries party facts; gift ask arrives separately
WhatsApp as the real medium	"All of our birthday party invitations are via WhatsApp now." (R37)	Templates should be designed for WhatsApp format
Age-scaled amount feels bossy	"Suggested amount: bossy. Parents chip in however much feels right." (R25)	Open-ended contribution may be preferable; or amount should be presented as a soft suggestion rather than a rule
Norm should be set at start of school year	"More easily delivered to a group of mums who know each other [...] at the start of the school year." (R35, R47)	One-time community-level norm-setting reduces per-party courage requirement
Spain / Bizum precedent	"In Spain it is standard to Bizum an amount. It was the shared norm." (R47)	Confirms that collective gifting norms are achievable; cultural precedent exists
Concept liked; design fails	"I like it in principle. [...] I agree [...] but these options focus on the gift more than the party." (R67)	Problem is not the idea but the execution; redesign is the intervention, not persuasion

10. From Survey to Design

The survey was not only a measurement instrument - it was a diagnostic tool. Through the IAE (Ideas–Arrangements–Effects) framework from the Design Studio for Social Intervention, the survey reveals that the persistent norm of individual gift-giving is not primarily a people problem (parents lacking courage or information) but an arrangement problem: the absence of any shared infrastructure that makes a collective alternative feel normal, low-risk, and socially endorsed.

The three dependent variables map directly onto three distinct design layers, each requiring a different kind of intervention:

Survey finding	Design layer	Platform response
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Clarity scores low across all invitations	Communication design	Invitation templates carry party facts only - date, time, location, RSVP - with no gift content on the front page
Appropriateness predicts willingness (rs = +0.74 to +0.91)	Structural design	The gift ask is never personally authored by the host; the platform surfaces contribution options automatically at the RSVP confirmation step
Pressure negatively predicts willingness (rs = -0.22 to -0.40)	Copy and tone	Contribution options are framed as optional and positive; charity donation offered as an alternative; no justificatory text
68.6% comfortable receiving vs 20% willing to send	Mechanism design	Platform-initiated rather than host-initiated ask removes the courage requirement from the individual transaction entirely

This mapping constitutes the core design argument of the capstone: the survey identified which layer of the problem each variable was measuring, and the platform design addresses each layer with a specific structural response. The theoretical contribution is not a new invitation persona - the survey showed these to be insufficient - but points to a potential new arrangement that routes the socially costly moment through infrastructure rather than through any individual parent's act of courage.

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